in using its plural-ist political system as a foreign policy asset.[51]

S. Jaishankar has articulated this thinking repeatedly in his speeches. Referring to India's "democratic way" as an "appealing" factor internationally, in 2016, he observed that "whether we are conscious of it or not, the world sees us espousing pluralistic values, often as an exemplar."[52] More recently, speaking in Washington, DC, he further elaborated on the strategic implications of India's political values and institutions:

> we don't kind of wear it [democracy] on our sleeve, but like any country, the things you believe in you are comfortable with other people in those societies who have similar thoughts. I do think today this [democracy] is a meeting ground between us [India and the United States]. … I think part of the Indian American relationship today is harmonizing our ways of pursuing our values and interests.[53]

India's appetite to promote its democratic culture abroad is not new. After the collapse of the Soviet Union, Indian leaders had even referred to democracy as an inevitable system worldwide. In 2005, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh emphasised that "liberal democracy is the natural order of political organization in today's world" and that "all alternate systems, authoritarian and majoritarian in varying degrees, are an aberration."[54] In 2003, Prime Minister A. B. Vajpayee had characterised India as a leading example of the "victorious march of democracy around the globe."[55]

The liberal link between domestic and international politics has been gaining more prominence in Indian strategic practice across three levels since then. First, India embraced a more normative language in its bilateral and multilateral foreign policy statements. For example, India's